

Colorado Field Ornithologists Sight Record Form

CFO-RC FILE X:

RESULTS:

Species:(Common Name) Baird's Sparrow

(Scientific Name) *Ammodramus bairdii*

Date(s) of occurrence: 22 April 2000

Number of birds seen: 2 - 3

Location: Comanche National Grasslands, Baca County

Length of observation: brief flights for 5 - 20 seconds for 1.5 hours Time(s) of observation: late morning

Other observers who saw the bird(s) with you: Mark Janos, Tony Leukering, Dave Quesenberry and others.

Conditions: windy, partly cloudy.

Optical equipment used: B & L Elite 10 x 42 binocular.

Distance from bird(s) (estimated unless otherwise noted): 1 - 140 meters

Photos: No.

Habitat: short grass prairie

Details: Norm Erthal led a group of us to look for Baird's Sparrows in the Comanche National Grasslands. We focused on the area where Dan Svingen found a singing bird in 1998 (CBRC # 1998-152). We spread out in a line and tried to stay about 5 meters apart and walked in relatively straight lines flushing sparrows. We flushed a few Grasshopper Sparrows (GRSP) and, then, a bird I felt was probably a Baird's Sparrow (BAIS). We never had a very good look at it, but the flight style, shape and color were consistent with BAIS (appeared the same as the last bird, but I did not see the underparts).

A bit later, we flushed another bird that looked larger than a GRSP, which I again thought was a BAIS. We stuck with this bird and flushed it about five times. We tried to find the bird on the ground when it landed, but never succeeded. In flight, the bird was larger and longer tailed than a GRSP. The flight style was generally like that of an *Ammodramus* sparrow. When it flushed, it would fly about 50 - 75 meters directly away, and make a 90-degree turn (roughly) and fly farther and dive into the grass. When dropping into the grass it would fan the tail (though not as much as GRSP), and we could see that it was not rounded as in GRSP. The upperparts were similar to GRSP but with more contrast. The outer tail feathers appeared paler (NOT white). At one point we had the bird completely surrounded. As we closed the circle it flew within a meter of me and I had excellent views of the head and underparts. As the bird flew up, I could see a buff median crown stripe (not very pale as in GRSP). The head was buff colored, with a dark spot behind the eye at the back of the auriculars and other spots dark spots around the auriculars. I could not see exactly where these spots were as the bird flew past. The overall affect was a pale buff head with dark markings. This made the bird look strikingly different from the numerous GRSP, which were plain faced. The pale white breast and flanks were streaked with black, more on the breast than flanks. The underparts were pale white (not buff).

We, later, found another bird and had similar luck with it. The flight style was the same, but I never had as good of a look. The long tail larger size, more contrasty upperparts, buff marked face, streaking on the breast made me confident it was a BAIS. Tony had a better look at this bird.

Much has been written on the similarity of BAIS and Savannah Sparrow (SAVS). To experienced observers, however, there is very little similarity in behavior, making confusion very unlikely. SAVS is approachable and often perches when flushed. It almost always gives flight notes when flushed (unlike BAIS which seem to rarely give them). In flight style is also much more buoyant and is unlikely to be confused by very experienced observers. That species rarely dives into the grass, fanning it tail. While I did not have stellar looks at the face, the overall buff color with some dark spots is unlike SAVS that shows a complete bold eyeline. I cannot imagine confusing BAIS and SAVS if I flush the bird and see it fly. GRSP is eliminated by shape, streaking on the breast and flanks and by the overall head coloration. From my work in Mexico, BAIS tends to fly away, make a 90-degree turn and fly some more. We saw GRSP do this rarely, and then, usually not to the same extent. Henslow's Sparrow would appear rufous winged in flight and have greener heads. That species occurrence in Colorado at this time is questionable at best. No other *Ammodramus* sparrow is likely to be confused.

Comments:

We found three BAIS without too much effort on a very windy day. This species is certainly an uncommon migrant in the state. Efforts at finding this bird on the eastern plains should demonstrate this species is regular in spring (and fall), which result in the removal of this species from the review list. I think concerted efforts in the few grassland locations in the San Luis Valley would be productive in finding this species.

What is your prior experience with this and similarly appearing species? Tony and I had just returned from a month of flushing grassland sparrows in Chihuahua and Durango, Mexico. During this time we had time to focus on flight identification of Grasshopper, Baird's and Savannah Sparrows (among others). While there, we were able to make confidently identify the majority of the birds we flushed. When we flushed a bird twice or more, we were able to confidently identify well-over 90% of the birds (and confirm these sightings with good views). In addition to the many Baird's I saw in Mexico I have seen wintering birds in Arizona and many breeders in North Dakota. I have seen hundreds of all other confusion species. I also have experience identifying birds in flight from my time in Cape May. While I obviously didn't see any of these species fly past, the challenges posed are similar.

Rec'd 2/19/01 rpl

(A) 7-0

List books, guides, recordings or other sources consulted and how this influenced your identification (during and after observation): Experience in Mexico. No books go into much detail on flight ID.

This report is from notes made immediately after observation.

Date of written report: 10 February 2001

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